Kalighat temple in Kolkata and other animals at Kali temples across the land, but most Hindu religious occasions are marked by ostentatious vegetarianism. My children's mother is half-Bengali, half-Kashmiri, descended from a long line of carnivorous Brahmins on both sides who were alternately horrified and mournful about my vegetarianism (some tried to excuse it on the grounds that I must be a 'Vaishnava', a worshipper of Vishnu, though I was too eclectic to be so typecast and had actually been named for Shiva, having been born on Maha Shivaratri. But then in Tamil, the word for vegetarian is 'shaiva'. Go figure!). We brought up our sons to 'eat everything', but their mixed genetic inheritance prevailed: one twin took to meat-eating with relish, while the other, at age seven, with no persuasion whatsoever from his father, turned staunchly vegetarian.

Alcohol offers its own contradictions. There is a strain of prohibition in some aspects of Hindu thought, but this coexists with the use of alcohol in some religious rituals (such as at the Kal Bhairava temples) and indeed with the routine habit, of some *sannyasi*s, of consuming marijuana and other hallucinogens in the pursuit of spiritual experiences. In the Vedas, *soma* (or *som-ras*) was a favourite beverage of the Vedic deities, and much alcohol flowed during religious ceremonies and sacrifices; in the *Rig Veda*, Mandala IV, Hymn 18, the god Indra is said to have drunk three lakes of *soma* to fortify himself before slaying the dragon Vritra, who had imprisoned all the waters of the world.[9] The *Mahabharata* is replete with details of alcohol consumed by those who are worshipped as incarnations of Vishnu. In Puranic mythology, there is a Hindu goddess of wine, Varuni, who emerged from the primordial Churning of the Ocean, the Samudra Manthan, as one of fourteen 'ratnas' bestowed upon the world, including the moon. Sanskrit literature, including the poetry and plays of Kalidasa, India's greatest literary figure (even though only a fraction of his sublime work has survived), is replete with references to intoxicating drinks. Yet other texts also offer Dharmashastric objections to Brahmins consuming liquor, and Brahminical Hinduism has tended to disapprove of alcohol consumption.